

HAGGAI

Introduction

Haggai was unique among God's prophets in that his hearers readily heeded the Lord's message. He did not preach against social sins, legal abuses, spiritual idolatry, syncretism, or adultery. Both the leadership and the citizenry obeyed his single motif: "Rebuild the temple."

Author

Scholars know little about Haggai. He may have been born on a feast day since his name is derived from חג, which means festival. Haggai ministered at the same time as Zechariah in the postexilic period. Ezra 5:1 and 6:4 corroborate this.

If Haggai was one of those "who saw this temple in its former glory" (2:3), he would have been an elderly man when he preached these four sermons. Yet it remains uncertain whether he meant to include himself in this phrase.

Date of Writing

The dating of this book is extremely unique since Haggai dated each of the four prophecies with precision. The first sermon occurred on August 29, 520 BC; the second on September 21, 520 BC; the third and fourth occurred on December 18, 520 BC. Therefore this book covered less than four months.

Historical Setting

Babylon fell to Cyrus of Medo-Persia in 539 BC. The following year Cyrus issued his famous decree allowing the Jews along with many others to return to their native homelands and rebuild their religious structures. About fifty thousand Jews availed themselves of Cyrus' offer and made the rigorous expedition to Jerusalem and Yehud. It seems they initiated the construction of the foundation of the second temple in 537 BC (Ezra 3:3-4). Work began on the temple itself in 536 BC (Ezra 3:8).

In 525 BC Cambyses successfully invaded Egypt. This assured peace throughout the Levant and made the possibility of revolt out of the question. The prophetic team of Haggai and Zechariah preached a religious nationalism without the Persian's scrutiny. While Zechariah targeted more the nationalistic motif, Haggai focused exclusively on religious themes.

Place of Writing

Haggai apparently wrote within Yehud and probably from Jerusalem. Both chapters contain references to the temple. Haggai 1:8 refers to mountains that contain wood. Connected with 1:11, it seems likely that these mountains are the Judean Hills.

Recipients

In his first message, Haggai addressed the governor of Yehud, Zerubbabel, and the High Priest, Joshua (1:1). The second message included Zerubbabel, Joshua, and "the

remnant of the people” (2:2). His third message focused on “the priests” (2:11) while in the fourth he spoke only to Zerubbabel (2:21).

Occasion and Purpose

Depending on the *terminus a quo* of the exile, the prophesied seventy years either had been realized or quickly approached fulfillment. Some had returned to Yehud, but initial enthusiasm regarding the construction had faded. Spiritual lethargy and despair characterized the people. They also faced economic difficulties, for although they lived in nice homes, they had recently experienced drought and want. The pestering by hostile neighbors also did not serve to encourage many.

To the audience mired in this confusion, Haggai preached that the solution was to rebuild the temple. This would mean the exchange of the covenantal cursings for the covenantal blessings.

Theme

Israel can have present hope through the rebuilding of the temple and future hope in the coming Messianic age when God again shakes the political system.

Argument

Introduction: This short book consists of four sermons. Haggai constructed the first message to arouse the Jews from their spiritual lethargy. Speaking for God, the prophet addressed Joshua, the High Priest, and Zerubbabel, the governor of Yehud and heir to the Davidic throne. The date was August 29, 520 BC.

I. FIRST MESSAGE: TO AROUSE (1:1-14)

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| A. Building Ceased | 1:1-4 |
| 1. Indifference to God | 1:1-2 |

Haggai immediately referred to the temple and pointed out that building had ceased (1:2-4). This displayed an indifference to God (1:2).

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| 2. Indulgence to Self | 1:3-4 |
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Conversely, this also exhibited a self-indulgence. While the common folk lived in upscale homes, the house of the Lord lay ruined and unattended.

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| B. Blessings Ceased | 1:5-11 |
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As a result, since construction of the temple had ceased, so the blessings from God had also ceased.

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| 1. Reflect upon Circumstances | 1:5-7 |
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Haggai asked Zerubbabel and Joshua, as administrative and spiritual leaders, to reflect upon the circumstances. Whether it was work, food, drink, clothes, or finances, they always were found lacking. Although they

had worked prudently and hard, their prosperity did not match their reasonable expectations. Thus Haggai asked them to consider their lives.

2. Rebuild the Lord's House 1:8

Haggai detailed the remedy for this dilemma. The nation must rebuild the Lord's House. They are to harvest wood from the mountains and begin construction. As a result of this action, God will be pleased and glorified.

3. Reasons for Chastisement 1:9-11

The prophet exhibited the reasons for chastisement. The people had focused on themselves and not the Lord; therefore the Lord had not prospered His people. The cause for this involved the Lord's covenantal character with its blessings and cursings.

C. Building Commenced 1:12-15

The building commenced as a result of this message.

1. Reaction of the People 1:12

The people responded immediately. Zerubbabel and Joshua led the people into obedience by demonstrating reverence for the Lord.

2. Return of the Blessings 1:13

Jehovah responded with a return of the blessings. Based upon the positive response of the people, Haggai encouraged them by stating that the Lord was with them in their work.

3. Return to the Work 1:14-15

In returning to the work, the people put their positive attitudes into actions. Thus, on September 20, 520 BC, about three weeks after Haggai's first sermon, the Lord's temple was again under active construction.

II. SECOND MESSAGE: TO ASSURE (2:1-9)

Haggai designed his second message to assure the people. This sermon, about seven weeks after the initial one, can be dated precisely to October 17, 520 BC.

A. People Regretting 2:1-3

In the midst of the construction, Haggai finds the people regretting the small size of this temple. Speaking to the entire nation, Haggai asked them to compare the Solomonic temple with the one undergoing erection. The new temple obviously was inferior to the previous one.

B. God Reassuring 2:4-9

Yet God reassured them.

1. Present Consolation 2:4-5

Haggai first examined the present consolation. One might assume that since the new temple is inferior to the old one, then God was not with His people. But God gave assurance that His Holy Spirit will indeed also abide in this temple.

2. Future Confidence 2:6-9

There will also be a future confidence.

a. Shaking of Nations 2:6-7a

The Lord of Armies tells of a coming shaking of the nations. Just as a political shaking occurred before and during the Exile, in the future this will occur once again.

b. Filling of Temple 2:7b-9

This upheaval will also result in the filling of the House of the Lord. God will once again fill His temple with glory and give peace to His people. Thus, while the Solomonic temple was externally superior to the one undergoing construction, the future temple's interior has yet to see its best days. The future will be more glorious than the past.

III. THIRD MESSAGE: TO AFFIRM (2:10-19)

Haggai preached the third message on December 18, 520 BC to affirm Israel. Hence it occurred about four months after the first message and two months after the second.

A. The Illustration of Contamination 2:10-13

Addressing the priesthood, Haggai presented an illustration involving contamination.

1. Holiness is not Communicable 2:10-12

First, Haggai made the observation that holiness is not communicable. He posed a hypothetical question: Can holiness be twice transmitted (from altar to meat to garment to bread)? The priests verified that holiness could not be caught.

2. Unholiness is Communicable 2:13

Haggai then made a converse observation. Unholiness is communicable. He presented the reverse hypothetical question: Is ceremonial defilement infectious under the same circumstances? The priests answered in the affirmative.

B. The Application to the Nation 2:14-17

The application to the nation came next, for Haggai applies the two hypothetical questions to the people. Looking at the past, the Lord explained that He caused the drought of water and prosperity due to the people's lack of obedience in rebuilding His temple.

C. The Annunciation of Material Abundance 2:18-19

The annunciation of material abundance climaxed this message. Eyeing the future, the Lord promised a reversal of His actions. Hence the nation will experience prosperity due to its obedience in the reconstruction of the temple.

IV. FOURTH MESSAGE: TO ANTICIPATE (2:20-23)

The fourth and concluding message addressed what God would do sometime in the future. Haggai gave this pronouncement to Zerubbabel also on December 18, 520 BC, apparently later in the day of his third sermon.

A. Destruction of the Nations 2:20-22

First, he noted the coming destruction of the nations. In the future the Lord will again shake the political world.

B. Distinction of Israel 2:23

During this time there will be a significant distinction for Israel. Addressing Zerubbabel with the messianic title of "My Servant," Jehovah declared that, as a result of this reshaking, Zerubbabel's Descendant will have a future role of leadership in this reshaping of the political scene. This introduced the notion of a glorious future for the nation of Israel with a ruling Messiah. Having begun on a negative note, Haggai thus ended with a positive chord.

Sentence Outline

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Israel can have present hope through the rebuilding of the temple and future hope in the coming Messianic age when God again shakes the political system.

- I.** Israel and its leadership should rise from their lethargy and thus build the temple. (1:1-14)

- A. The two reasons the building of God's house had ceased are the people's indifference to God and the people's indulgence. (1:1-4)
 - 1. The first reason is the people's indifference to God. (1:1-2)
 - 2. The second reason involved the people's indulgence by living in beautiful homes while God's abode remained desolate. (1:3-2)
- B. Since the nation had ceased building God's house, God's blessings on His people have also ceased. (1:5-11)
 - 1. Reflecting on the past, the people should have been greatly blessed, but do not presently experience such blessing. (1:5-7)
 - 2. The remedy for this lack of God's blessing is to begin building God's house. (1:8)
 - 3. The reason for God's chastisement on His people is that the people focused on themselves, not their God. (1:9-11)
- C. As a result, the people in obedience began to rebuild the temple, anticipating the Lord's blessing. (1:12-15)
 - 1. The people promised to obey the prophet/Lord. (1:12)
 - 2. The Lord then promised to prosper the people. (1:13)
 - 3. The people, led by the governor and High Priest, began to rebuild the temple. (1:14-15)

II. Israel is assured that what they were doing was the right thing to do. (2:1-9)

- A. The people were regretting the small size of the new temple. (2:1-3)
- B. God reassured the people that they were doing the correct thing with blessings yet to come. (2:4-9)
 - 1. God promised that soon His Holy Spirit would live in this temple as well. (2:4-5)
 - 2. God also promised that in the future He would shake the political world. (2:6-9)
 - a. In the future God would shake the Gentiles. (2:6-7a)
 - b. Also, in the future God would once again grace His temple with His Holy Spirit. (2:7b-9)

III. Israel is affirmed in their task of rebuilding the temple. (2:10-19)

- A. Haggai presents an illustration of contamination. (2:10-13)
 - 1. Holiness is not communicable. (2:10-12)
 - 2. Unholiness is communicable. (2:13)
- B. Haggai then applies the illustration by linking the past drought of water and prosperity with the people's disobedience. (2:14-17)
- C. Conversely, the people's present obedience will bring rain and prosperity. (2:18-19)

IV. God would shake the Gentile world and give Israel a glorious Messiah in the distant future. (2:20-23)

- A. God would again shake the political Gentile world. (2:20-22)
- B. Conversely, God would give Israel a glorious future with the Messiah as ruler. (2:23)

Simple Outline

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(Adapted from Harold W. Hoehner)

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